Shaozhe Cheng

Curriculum Vitae
September, 2026

Contact Information

Department of Psychology & Neuroscience
Duke University; Durham, NC; 27708; USA

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Appointments

Duke University

Postdoctoral Associate, Early Childhood Cognition Lab — 2026–
Visiting Postdoctoral Scholar — 2024–2026
Mentors/Collaborators: Tamar Kushnir & Michael Tomasello

UCLA

Postdoctoral Scholar, Visual Intelligence Lab — 2024–2026
Mentor: Tao Gao

Education

Ph.D., Cognitive Psychology, Zhejiang University — 2023
Advisors: Jifan Zhou (ZJU), Mowei Shen (ZJU), Tao Gao (UCLA)
Dissertation: *On the nature and origins of the unique human mind: Intentional commitment under conflicting desires* **(Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award)**

B.S., Psychology, Shanghai Normal University — 2016

Research Interests

Computational cognitive science; social cognition; decision-making; agency; human–AI coordination; cooperative AI

Awards and Honors

- Travel Award, Charles Lafitte Foundation — 2026
- Early-Career Scholar, Intentions & AI Workshop — 2025
- Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award of Zhejiang Province — 2024
- Outstanding Doctoral Dissertation Award of Zhejiang University — 2023
- Cognitive Science Society Conference Award — 2021
- National Scholarship for Postgraduates — 2017

Fellowships & Grants

- **British Academy International Fellowship**, The British Academy — 2027–2029
  Award holder; Host: University College London (UCL) | £274,329
- **Funding for Outstanding Doctoral Dissertations** — 2021–2022
  Zhejiang University | ¥960,000

Publications

Cheng, S., & Tomasello, M. (invited submission). Can We Get to Human-Like Intelligence Via Language Alone?

Cheng, S., Gao T., Tomasello, M., & Kushnir, T. (2026). The Agency Gap: Testing Human–Human and Human–AI Collaboration Using a Minimal Coordination Game. *Proceedings of the 48th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.* (Presented as a **spotlight** research talk (top 10%) at Conference on Society-Centered AI.)

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2026). Should we commit or should we switch? Goal alignment in sequential social coordination. *Proceedings of the 48th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.* (Presented as an oral talk (9.3%))

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2026). Spontaneous coordination with self-commitment: How the presence of others alters the strength, goal and timing of commitment. *Cognition. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2025.106287*

Zhai, S[#]., **Cheng, S[#].**, Moskowitz, N., Shen, M., & Gao, T. (2024). The development of commitment: Attention for intention. *Child Development*, 95(1), 7-15. https://doi.org/10.1111/cdev.13955
[#] Shared first authors

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Tang, N., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2023). Intention beyond desire: Spontaneous intentional commitment regulates conflicting desires. *Cognition*, 238, 105513. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cognition.2023.105513

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2022). Intentional commitment through an internalized theory of mind: Acting in the eyes of an imagined observer. In *Proceedings of the 44th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society.*

Cheng, S., Zhao, M., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2022). Intentional commitment as goal perseverance in human planning [Workshop on Social Intelligence in Humans and Robots]. *The annual meeting of the Robotics: Science and Systems 2022 (RSS 2022).* (presented as a **spotlight** paper at https://social-intelligence-human-ai.github.io/)

Cheng, S., Shi, B., Zhao, Y., Tang, N., Xu., H., Gao, T., Zhou J., & Shen, M. (2017) Rethinking attention: A reinforcement learning model of attention. *Chinese Journal of Applied Psychology.*

Conference Presentations

^Students I supervised

Cheng, S., Gao, T., Tomasello, M., & Kushnir, T. (2026, June 18–20). *The agency gap: Testing human–human and human–AI collaboration using a minimal coordination game* [Poster presentation]. The Society for Philosophy and Psychology 52nd Annual Meeting, Baltimore, MD, United States.

Kushnir, T., & **Cheng, S.** (2026, Apr). Children's strategic joint decision-making with

minimally social artificial agents. Pre-Conference Workshops on *Strategic decision-making in childhood, Cognitive Development Society (CDS)*, Montreal, Quebec, Canada.

Cheng, S., Gao T., Tomasello, M., & Kushnir, T. (2026, Feb). The Agency Gap: Testing Human–Human and Human–AI Collaboration Using a Minimal Coordination Game. Presented as a spotlight research talk (top 10%) at *Conference on Society-Centered AI*, Duke University, Durham, NC, USA.

Cheng, S., Main, K^., Kushnir, T., & Gao, T. (2025, May). Spontaneous social coordination through visually grounded theory-of-mind in children's and adults' decision-making. Poster accepted at *the Annual Meeting of the Vision Sciences Society*, St. Pete Beach, Florida, USA.

Cheng, S., Main, K^., Gao, T., & Kushnir, T. (2025, May). Children's Spontaneous Commitment and Intention Coordination in Individual and Social Decision-Making Contexts. Talk at the Symposium: Unravelling early and middle childhood decision-making: From individual characteristics to social influences, *Society for Research in Child Development Biennial Meeting (SRCD 2025)*, Minneapolis, MN, USA.

Cheng, S., Zhu, J., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2024). Intentional commitment as a spontaneous presentation of self. Poster presented at *Proceedings of the 46th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society.*

Cheng, S., Zhu, J^., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2024). From attention capture to social coordination: "Abrupt onset" rallies joint planning. Poster presented at the 2024 VSS Annual Meeting. Vision Sciences Society.

Zhu, J^., **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). Viewing others as committed agents. Poster presented at *the 2023 SPSP Annual Convention. Society for Personality and Social Psychology*.

Zhu, J^., **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). Intention as hierarchical constraints in human planning. Poster presented at *the 2023 VSS Annual Meeting. Vision Sciences Society.*

Zhu, J^., **Cheng, S.**, Gao T., Shui, R., Shen, M., & Zhou J. (2023). People expect others to plan with consistency to intention. Poster presented at *the 2023 APS Annual Convention. Association for Psychological Science.*

Zhai, S., **Cheng, S.**, Moskowitz, N., Shen, M., & Gao, T. (2022). The development of commitment: Attention for intention. Oral presentation at *the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Cheng, S., Tang, N., An, W., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2021). Intention beyond desire: Commitment in human action. Poster presented at *the 47th annual meeting of the Society for Philosophy and Psychology*, 6/28/21 – 7/2/21, *Virtual-SPP*.

Cheng, S., Tang, N., An, W., Zhao, Y., Zhou J., Shen, M., & Gao T. (2020). Intention beyond desire: Commitment in human action. Poster presented at *the annual meeting of the Vision Sciences Society*, 6/19/20 – 6/24/20, *Virtual-VSS*.

Cheng, S., Xu, H., Tang, N., Zhou J., Chen, H., Liang, J., Gao T., & Shen, M. (2018). Hierarchical Constrains on the Distribution of Attention in Dynamic Displays. Poster presented at *the 30th APS Annual Convention*.

Invited Talks

Cheng, S. Test commitment in humans (adults and kids) and AIs (RL agents and LLMs) in sequential decision-making. Talk given at the Intentions & AI Workshop, CA, 6/2/2025.

Cheng, S. On the nature and origins of the unique human mind: Intentional commitment under conflicting desires. Talk given at the Tomasello Lab, Duke University, NC, 4/18/2025.

Cheng, S. Spontaneous coordination through intentional commitment: How adults and children resolve conflicting desires in sequential decision-making. Talk given at the Communication Colloquium, UCLA, CA, 4/10/2025.

Teaching

Teaching Assistant	*Zhejiang University*: **Psychology and Artificial Intelligence** (undergraduate course), 2018 & 2019
Guest Lecturer	*Zhejiang University*: **Evolutionary Psychology** (undergraduate seminar), 2017 & 2018 *Zhejiang University*: **Advanced Psychological Research Methods** (graduate course), 2019 & 2020

Mentorship

PhD Students	Jingyin Zhu (ZJU `24)
Master Students	Shaoyan Hao (ZJU `25)
Undergraduate Senior Theses	Kaelin Main (Duke `25)
	Riley MacDermott (Duke `27)
	Camila Acquarone (Duke `27)

Award & Funding to Trainees

Duke Summer Vertical Integration Program (VIP)	Riley MacDermott (Duke `27)	2026
Duke Summer Vertical Integration Program (VIP)	Kaelin Main (Duke `25)	2024

Ad Hoc Reviewer

Science Robotics
Journal of Experimental Psychology: General
Cognition
The Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society
Society for Philosophy and Psychology